Wars are unforgiving. What will you do then? In the last few metres during a run, every single drop of blood matters, every bit of energy matters, every stride matters. Winners aren't those who put all their effort into the beginning of the run; winners are those who do not give up in the last few metres. Now, you must understand that you're running the last few metres. Do you want to see yourself win?'

I slowly turned and looked at Papaji. There was a smile on his face, a smile I remember even to this day. He was clearly proud of his daughter—he had said it so many times that day. He had telephoned his course mates and bragged about me getting recommended. My recommendation was a milestone achievement for my parents. He was happy and I didn't want to spoil the day for him. 'I will try my best,' I said and hugged him.

That night as I slept, Papaji chalked out a four-week diet plan for me. My diet was suddenly shifted from paranthas, butter chicken and rotis to fruits, salads, low carbohydrates and curd, and lots of water. Not only this, he even planned my daily physical-training regimen. Never in my life had it occurred to me that I might have to diet someday. And for the food lover that I was, it was going to be one hell of a ride. It did not affect only me, but my entire family had to shift to eating salads and food that was low in calories. Maa thought that it might affect my morale if they all ate regular food while I survived on salads.

Papaji woke me up at half past four the next morning and took me for a run, almost against my will. I started panting after only a few minutes, but Papaji kept motivating me. 'At least finish a kilometre today, and then we'll gradually increase the distance,' he said. After an exhausting morning session, I was given plain vegetable salad without salt for breakfast. Somehow, I managed to swallow the tasteless veggies. It went to Maa's heart to see me suffer but Dada seemed quite amused. 'If only you had listened to me and exercised regularly,' he commented. The morning took a toll on me and added to my frustration. If that wasn't all, Papaji's unit juniors—two captains and a lieutenant—called on Papaji during lunch.

In line with the age-old traditions of the army, Maa and Papaji had to succumb to every demand of the guests. As a result, a plethora of cuisines